Stop Flying Blind

The Complete GA4 + Shopify Analytics Setup for Small Business

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About This Playbook

You paid $79 for this. That's a good sign — it means you're done guessing.

This playbook is for Shopify store owners and ecommerce operators who are either:

- **Flying blind** — no analytics set up properly, no idea what's working
- **Drowning in data** — GA4 is installed, numbers are everywhere, none of it makes sense

- **Burned before** — you had someone set up tracking, something broke, you gave up

None of that matters now. By the time you finish this guide, you'll have a working analytics stack, five essential reports, a weekly routine that takes fifteen minutes, and a clear view of what's actually driving (or killing) your revenue.

This is not theory. Every step in this playbook has been validated on real Shopify stores across Australia, New Zealand, and the UK. The benchmarks are real. The mistakes are ones we've seen — and helped fix — dozens of times.

Let's get into it.

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1. Introduction — Why Your Analytics Are Probably Lying to You

Let's start with an uncomfortable truth.

Most Shopify store analytics are broken. Not "slightly off" — broken. Inflated traffic numbers, missing revenue data, sessions attributed to the wrong channel, conversion rates that don't match your actual sales. And because the numbers look plausible, most business owners never question them.

You make decisions based on those numbers. You spend money based on those numbers. And then you wonder why your marketing feels like it's not working.

Here's what's actually happening.

The Four Most Common Ways Your Data Is Already Wrong

1. You Installed GA4, But You Didn't Configure It

Google Analytics 4 is not plug-and-play. Installing the tracking code gets you some data — but without proper configuration, you're missing:

- Purchase events (the most important thing)
- Accurate channel attribution
- Internal traffic (your own visits inflating numbers)
- Cross-domain tracking (if you have any redirects or payment gateways)
- Proper event parameters that give context to what people are doing

A store we audited last year had 47 goals set up in the old Universal Analytics. When they migrated to GA4, none of those carried over. They'd been "tracking" for eight months with effectively nothing but pageviews.

2. Your Shopify and GA4 Aren't Talking Properly

Shopify has its own analytics. GA4 has its analytics. They should agree — they almost never do.

The reasons include: - Checkout pages loading in a subdomain (`checkout.mystore.com.au`) that breaks the tracking session - Payment gateway redirects (Afterpay, Zip, PayPal) that drop the referral and make every purchase look like it came from "direct" traffic - The GA4 Shopify integration using the old Google Analytics app instead of the new native integration - Duplicate tracking from both the Shopify theme and a third-party app firing events twice

When Shopify says you made 340 sales and GA4 says you made 198, someone's lying. (Usually GA4 — but not always.)

3. You're Looking at Vanity Metrics

Sessions. Pageviews. Bounce rate. These numbers feel useful. They move around, they respond to things you do, and they give the impression of momentum.

But here's the test: Can you draw a direct line from any of those metrics to revenue? If a session goes up 20%, does your revenue go up 20%? Probably not.

The metrics that actually matter for an ecommerce store are: - Revenue by channel - Conversion rate by source - Average order value - Customer acquisition cost - Return customer rate

These are the numbers you need to make decisions. Everything else is context.

4. You're Missing Attribution Windows

Someone clicks your Instagram post. They browse, don't buy. Three days later they Google your brand name, find your site, and buy.

What channel gets credit?

In most default GA4 setups: **Google / organic**. Because that was the last click.

But the Instagram post started that journey. If you kill your Instagram budget based on GA4's last-click attribution, you might be cutting the top of a funnel that was actually working.

Attribution is genuinely complex, and we'll cover it properly in this guide. But the first step is knowing it's a problem.

What "Fixed" Looks Like

When your analytics stack is set up properly, you can answer these questions confidently:

- Where did my revenue come from this month?
- What's my cost per new customer, by channel?
- Which products have the best (and worst) conversion rates?
- Where are people abandoning their carts?
- Are my Google Ads profitable?
- What percentage of my orders are from returning customers?
- What's changed since last month, and why?

That's what this playbook builds toward. Not dashboards for their own sake — the ability to make better decisions, faster, with less guessing.

A Note on GA4 vs Universal Analytics

If you've been in ecommerce for more than a few years, you probably used Universal Analytics (UA). It was deprecated in July 2023, and historical UA data is no longer accessible through the standard interface.

GA4 is different. It's built on an event-based model rather than session-based, which is more flexible but also more confusing out of the box. The interface is different. The reports are different. The logic is different.

This guide is written entirely for GA4. If someone tells you to do something "the old way," check whether they're giving you UA advice dressed up as GA4 advice. It happens constantly, and it leads to broken setups.

How to Use This Playbook

If you're starting from scratch: Read the whole thing in order. Parts 1 and 2 build on each other, and skipping ahead will leave gaps.

If you have GA4 installed but it feels broken: Start with Part 1 (fixing your foundation), then go to the Audit Checklist at the back to identify specific issues.

If your setup is solid and you want better reporting: Jump straight to Part 2 (the five reports) and Part 3 (the weekly ritual).

If you're running Google Ads: Part 4 is essential. Don't skip it.

Allow yourself two to three hours to work through the setup sections. The reporting sections you can read without being at your computer.

Let's get started.

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2. The Analytics Stack That Actually Works

Before we touch any settings, let's be clear about what you're building and why each piece matters.

The stack for a Shopify store running Google Ads looks like this:

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	COST
Google Analytics 4	Tracks user behaviour, conversions, revenue by channel	Free
Google Search Console	Shows search rankings, clicks, impressions, indexing status	Free
Google Ads	Paid traffic management + conversion tracking	Ad spend only
Shopify Analytics	Native order/revenue reporting, your source of truth	Included
Google Tag Manager	Manages all tracking tags from one place (optional but recommended)	Free

These four free tools, connected properly, give you everything you need to run a data-informed Shopify business without paying for a dashboard tool until you're ready.

Why These Four, and Not Something Else?

There are dozens of analytics tools marketed at ecommerce businesses. Klaviyo analytics, Triple Whale, Northbeam, Rockerbox, Littledata — the list goes on. Some of them are genuinely excellent. Most of them are expensive.

The tools above are free, they're owned by Google (which means deep integration with Google Ads and Search), they're the industry standard, and they're what any agency or freelancer will know how to use.

Once you have this stack working correctly, you'll have the foundation to layer in paid tools if you need them. But you don't need them to start.

What Each Tool Is Actually For

Google Analytics 4 — Your Behaviour Layer

GA4 tells you what people do on your site:

- Where they came from (what channel, what source, what campaign)
- What they looked at
- What they added to cart
- Where they dropped off
- Who converted and what they bought

Think of GA4 as your audience's behaviour, captured.

Google Search Console — Your Search Performance Layer

Search Console tells you how your site performs in Google Search:

- Which keywords are bringing people to your site
- Your average ranking position for those keywords
- Click-through rates from search results
- Which pages are indexed (and which aren't)
- Technical issues affecting your search visibility

GA4 will show you that you got 500 sessions from organic search this month. Search Console will tell you which queries brought those 500 people, and whether your rankings are trending up or down.

Google Ads — Your Paid Traffic Layer

Google Ads manages your paid campaigns — Search, Shopping, Performance Max, Display, and YouTube. When connected to GA4 and Search Console, it gives you conversion data at the keyword and ad level, letting you see exactly which spend is generating revenue.

Shopify Analytics — Your Revenue Source of Truth

Shopify knows about every order placed on your store. It doesn't have the behaviour data GA4 has, but it has perfect order data: revenue, products sold, discount codes used, customer history.

When there's a discrepancy between Shopify and GA4, **trust Shopify for revenue figures**. GA4 can miss transactions due to ad blockers, slow page loads, or tracking gaps. Shopify can't miss an order because an order is what generates money.

A Word on Google Tag Manager

Google Tag Manager (GTM) is a tool that lets you manage all your tracking tags — GA4, Google Ads conversion tracking, Facebook Pixel, etc. — from one place, without touching your theme code every time.

Should you use it for Shopify?

If you're running Google Ads and GA4 together, and you want to track custom events beyond what Shopify's native integration provides: yes, GTM is worth setting up.

If you're just getting started and you want to keep things simple: Shopify's native GA4 integration (via the Google & YouTube app) gets you 80% of the way there without GTM.

This playbook covers both approaches. We'll flag where GTM becomes relevant.

Setting Expectations

Implementing this stack properly takes time. Not because it’s technically difficult, but because there are many moving parts, and each one needs to be checked.

The good news: you only do the setup once. Once it’s working, maintenance is minimal — mostly checking quarterly that nothing has broken.

Part 1: Fixing Your Foundation

GA4 Setup Checklist (Step by Step)

This section walks you through a complete GA4 setup — or a complete audit of an existing setup. Work through every step, even if you think your GA4 is already set up. Most “already set up” GA4 accounts are missing at least three things on this list.

Step 1: Create or Access Your GA4 Property

1. Go to analytics.google.com
2. Sign in with the Google account associated with your business (not your personal Gmail)
3. Click the **Admin** gear icon in the bottom left
4. Under **Account**, check you’re in the right account
5. Under **Property**, check whether a GA4 property already exists

If no property exists: 1. Click **Create Property** 2. Enter your property name (e.g., “YourStore.com.au — GA4”) 3. Set your reporting time zone to **Australia/Sydney** (or your local timezone) 4. Set your currency to **AUD** 5. Click **Next**, select your business type (**Shopping** or **Retail**) 6. Select **Business objectives** — choose “Examine user behaviour” and “Generate leads/sales” 7. Click **Create**

If a property already exists: Check the property name and whether it ends in a GA4 Measurement ID format (G-XXXXXXXXXX). If you see a UA-XXXXXXXXX ID, that’s a Universal Analytics property — it’s deprecated and you need to create a new GA4 property.

Step 2: Configure Your Data Stream

A data stream is the connection between your website and GA4. You need exactly one web data stream for your Shopify store.

1. In Admin, under **Property**, click **Data Streams**
2. If a stream exists, click on it to review. If not, click **Add stream → Web**
3. Enter your website URL (e.g., `https://yourstore.com.au`)
4. Enter a stream name (e.g., "YourStore Web")
5. Leave **Enhanced Measurement** turned **on** — this automatically tracks scrolls, outbound clicks, video plays, and file downloads
6. Click **Create stream**

Copy your Measurement ID (format: G-XXXXXXXXXX) — you'll need this to connect to Shopify.

Step 3: Configure Data Retention

By default, GA4 only retains event-level data for **2 months**. This means you can't run reports comparing data from more than two months ago at an event level.

Change this immediately:

1. In Admin → **Property** → **Data Settings** → **Data Retention**
2. Change **Event data retention** from 2 months to **14 months**
3. Turn on **Reset user data on new activity**
4. Click **Save**

> **Why this matters:** Without 14-month retention, you can't do year-on-year comparisons in your standard reports. You'll only notice this is a problem about 6 months after you needed to fix it.

Step 4: Filter Out Internal Traffic

Every time you visit your own website, GA4 records it as a session. If you're checking your store regularly (and you should be), your own visits are inflating your traffic numbers and reducing your conversion rate.

First, find your IP address: Go to whatismyip.com and note your IP address. If you work from multiple locations (home, office, café), note all of them.

Then, create an internal traffic filter:

1. In Admin → **Data Streams** → click your web stream
2. Scroll to **More tagging settings** → **Define internal traffic**
3. Click **Create**
4. Name it "Internal — [Your Name/Office]"
5. Set rule: **IP address matches regex** — enter your IP
6. Click **Save**

Then activate the filter:

1. In Admin → **Data Settings** → **Data Filters**
2. Click **Internal Traffic**
3. Change status from **Testing** to **Active**
4. Click **Save**

> **Warning:** If you skip this, a store owner who checks their site 10 times a day can account for 5-10% of their own "traffic." We've seen conversion rates tank overnight when internal filter was turned on — because the traffic inflating the denominator was the owner themselves.

Step 5: Set Up Cross-Domain Tracking

If your store uses a separate checkout domain (which Shopify does — `checkout.shopify.com` for older setups, or `checkout.yourstore.com.au` for custom domains), you need cross-domain tracking to ensure sessions aren't broken when a customer moves between domains.

1. In Admin → **Data Streams** → click your web stream

2. Click **Configure tag settings**
3. Click **Configure your domains**
4. Add your main domain AND your checkout domain
5. Click **Save**

Common domains to add: - `yourstore.com.au` - `checkout.yourstore.com.au` (if using Shopify Plus or custom checkout) - Any additional domains where your store content lives

> **Note:** For most Shopify stores on the standard plan, Shopify's native GA4 integration handles checkout tracking. But if you're using the GTM method or a third-party integration, cross-domain setup is critical.

Step 6: Mark Referral Exclusions

Payment gateways like PayPal, Afterpay, Zip, and others redirect customers away from your site and back. Without exclusions, GA4 treats the return from the payment gateway as a new session from that referral — making all your purchases appear to come from "paypal / referral" or "afterpay / referral."

1. In Admin → **Data Streams** → click your web stream
2. Click **Configure tag settings**
3. Click **List unwanted referrals**
4. Add each payment gateway you use:
    - `paypal.com`
    - `afterpay.com`
    - `zip.co`
    - `zippay.com.au`
    - `humm.com.au` (formerly Oxipay)
    - `klarna.com`
    - `laybuy.com`
    - `openpay.com.au`
5. Click **Save**

> **Tip:** Check your Shopify Payments settings and look at what payment methods are enabled. Add all of them to this list.

Step 7: Configure Google Signals

Google Signals lets GA4 use Google's cross-device data to stitch together user journeys across devices — when users are signed into their Google accounts.

1. In Admin → **Property Settings** → **Google Signals Data Collection**
2. Click **Get Started**
3. Follow the activation steps
4. Click **Activate**

This improves remarketing audiences and cross-device reporting. It's optional but recommended.

Step 8: Link Google Search Console

1. In Admin → **Property Links** → **Search Console Links**
2. Click **Link**
3. Click **Choose accounts** and select your Search Console property
4. Select your web stream
5. Click **Next → Submit**

If you haven't verified your site in Search Console yet, do that first (covered in Part 4).

Step 9: Link Google Ads

1. In Admin → **Property Links** → **Google Ads Links**
2. Click **Link**
3. Select your Google Ads account

4. Enable **Enable auto-tagging**
5. Click **Next → Submit**

Auto-tagging adds a `gclid` parameter to your Google Ads URLs, which allows GA4 to correctly attribute sessions and conversions to specific campaigns, ad groups, and keywords.

Step 10: Verify Your Setup

Give it 24-48 hours after connecting everything, then run these checks:

Check 1: Real-time data 1. Open your Shopify store in an incognito window 2. In GA4, go to **Reports → Realtime** 3. You should see yourself appear within a few seconds

Check 2: Purchase events 1. Place a test order on your store (use a discount code to make it $0, or use Shopify's test payment gateway) 2. In GA4 → **Reports → Realtime** 3. Look for a `purchase` event firing

Check 3: Enhanced Measurement events 1. Browse your store in incognito 2. Scroll down a product page 3. Click an external link if any exist 4. Check Realtime for `scroll` and `click` events

Check 4: Revenue data (after 24h) 1. Go to **Reports → Monetisation → Ecommerce Purchases** 2. Confirm you can see product data if you've processed any orders in the last day

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Key Events to Track (and Which Ones Don't Matter)

GA4's event-based model means you can track almost anything. The question isn't what you can track — it's what's actually worth your attention.

Here's the complete breakdown.

Events You Must Have (These Are Non-Negotiable)

EVENT	WHAT IT CAPTURES	WHY IT MATTERS
`purchase`	Completed transactions with revenue, items, order ID	Your most important conversion event
`add_to_cart`	Product added to cart	Top of the purchase funnel
`begin_checkout`	Checkout started	Middle of the funnel
`add_payment_info`	Payment details entered	Near-bottom of funnel
`view_item`	Product page viewed	Understanding product interest
`view_item_list`	Collection/category page viewed	What categories get attention

If you're using Shopify's native GA4 integration (via the Google & YouTube Sales Channel), all of these fire automatically. If you're using GTM, you'll need to configure them.

Events That Are Useful (Track These Too)

EVENT	WHAT IT CAPTURES	WHY IT MATTERS
`search`	On-site search queries	Shows what customers can't find easily
`view_promotion`	Banner/promotion interactions	Measures effectiveness of homepage promotions
`select_promotion`	Clicks on promotions	Conversion rate of promotional banners
`remove_from_cart`	Items removed from cart	Identifies consideration-stage hesitation
`login`	Account logins	Tracks returning customer engagement
`sign_up`	Account creation	Newsletter/account growth

Events That Are Nice to Have (Low Priority)

EVENT	WHAT IT CAPTURES
`scroll` (Enhanced Measurement)	How far down pages users scroll
`file_download`	PDF or other downloads
`video_start` / `video_complete`	Video engagement (if you have product videos)
`outbound_click`	Clicks to external sites

Events You Can Ignore (For Now)

- `page_view` — GA4 tracks this automatically. You don't need to configure it, and it rarely drives actionable decisions on its own.
- `session_start` — Automatic. Background plumbing.
- `first_visit` — Automatic. Useful eventually for new vs returning analysis, but not day-to-day.
- `user_engagement` — Automatic. Measures active time on page. Low priority.

Configuring Conversions

In GA4, a "conversion" is any event you mark as important. You should mark the following as conversions:

1. In Admin → **Events**
2. Find `purchase` — toggle **Mark as conversion** to ON
3. Also mark `begin_checkout` (useful for funnel analysis)
4. Optionally mark `add_to_cart` (if you want to track micro-conversions)

> **Important:** Do NOT mark `page_view` or `session_start` as conversions. This is a surprisingly common mistake — it makes your conversion rate look astronomically high and renders the metric meaningless.

Custom Events Worth Creating

Once your foundation is solid, these custom events add valuable depth:

`add_to_wishlist` — If your store has a wishlist feature, this helps you understand aspiration vs purchase intent.

`contact_form_submit` — If you have a contact form, track form submissions as a lead event.

`loyalty_signup` — If you have a loyalty programme, track when customers join it.

`review_submitted` — Tracking product review submissions helps you understand engagement.

To create custom events in GA4: 1. Go to **Configure → Events → Create event** 2. Name your event (use lowercase with underscores: `contact_form_submit`) 3. Set matching conditions based on an existing event (e.g., `page_view` where page path contains `/contact/success`)

Shopify + GA4 Connection (Step by Step)

There are three ways to connect Shopify to GA4. We'll cover all three, in order of simplicity.

Method 1: Shopify's Native Google Integration (Recommended for Most Stores)

Shopify's Google & YouTube Sales Channel includes built-in GA4 integration. This is the simplest approach and covers 80-85% of tracking needs.

What it tracks automatically: - All standard ecommerce events (view_item, add_to_cart, begin_checkout, purchase) - User sessions and pageviews - Product and revenue data

What it doesn't cover: - Some advanced custom events - Granular parameter customisation - Third-party payment gateway return tracking in some edge cases

Setup steps:

1. **In Shopify Admin:** Go to **Apps → Browse apps**
2. Search for **"Google & YouTube"** — this is Shopify's official channel app
3. Click **Add app → Install**
4. After installation, click **Get started** in the Google & YouTube app
5. **Connect your Google account** — use the same Google account connected to your GA4 property
6. Under **Analytics**, click **Connect to Google Analytics**
7. Select your **GA4 Property** from the dropdown

8. Click **Connect**

Verify the connection: 1. Go to your store in an incognito window and browse a few product pages 2. In GA4 → **Reports → Realtime** 3. You should see events firing within 30-60 seconds

Important — Check for Duplicate Tracking:

If you previously had another GA4 integration (an older Google Analytics app, a third-party Shopify plugin, or a manually placed tag), you may now have duplicate tracking. Duplicate tracking causes: - Double-counted pageviews - Double-counted revenue (GA4 shows twice what Shopify shows) - Inflated conversion rates

To check: 1. Open your store in a browser 2. Press **F12** → **Network tab** 3. Browse to a product page and filter for `collect` or `g/collect` requests 4. If you see the same GA4 Measurement ID appearing **twice**, you have duplicate tracking

To fix: Remove any manually added GA4 scripts from your Shopify theme, and disable/remove any older Google Analytics Shopify apps.

Method 2: Google Tag Manager (Advanced but More Flexible)

If you want more control over what's tracked and how — or if you're also tracking Facebook/Meta, TikTok, or other platforms — Google Tag Manager is the better long-term choice.

Why GTM? - One place to manage all your tracking tags - Can handle complex custom events - Easier to update tracking without touching code - Works better for stores with custom checkout flows

Step 1: Create a GTM Account and Container

1. Go to tagmanager.google.com
2. Click **Create account**
3. Account name: your business name
4. Container name: your website URL
5. Target platform: **Web**
6. Click **Create**
7. Accept the terms

8. Copy the two code snippets provided (head snippet and body snippet)

Step 2: Add GTM to Your Shopify Theme

1. In Shopify Admin → **Online Store → Themes**
2. Click **Actions → Edit code** on your active theme
3. Open `theme.liquid`
4. **Head snippet:** Paste the GTM head code immediately after the `<head>` tag:

```
<!-- Google Tag Manager -->
<script>(function(w,d,s,l,i){w[l]=w[l]||[];w[l].push({'gtm.start':
new Date().getTime(),event:'gtm.js'});var f=d.getElementsByTagName(s)[0],
j=d.createElement(s),dl=l!='dataLayer'?'&l='+l:'';j.async=true;j.src=
'https://www.googletagmanager.com/gtm.js?
        id='+i+dl;f.parentNode.insertBefore(j,f);
})(window,document,'script','dataLayer','GTM-XXXXXXX');</script>
<!-- End Google Tag Manager -->
```

(Replace GTM-XXXXXXX with your actual GTM container ID)

1. **Body snippet:** Paste the GTM body code immediately after the `<body>` tag:

```
<!-- Google Tag Manager (noscript) -->
<noscript><iframe src="https://www.googletagmanager.com/ns.html?id=GTM-
        XXXXXXX"
height="0" width="0" style="display:none;visibility:hidden"></iframe></
        noscript>
<!-- End Google Tag Manager (noscript) -->
```

1. Click **Save**

Step 3: Add GTM to Shopify's Checkout (Shopify Plus Only)

Standard Shopify doesn't allow custom JavaScript on the checkout page. If you're on Shopify Plus, you can add GTM to `checkout.liquid`. For standard Shopify, use Method 1 for checkout tracking or the Additional Scripts method below.

For standard Shopify — Order Confirmation page:

1. In Shopify Admin → **Settings → Checkout**
2. Scroll to **Order status page**
3. In the **Additional scripts** box, add:

```
<script>
  window.dataLayer = window.dataLayer || [];
  window.dataLayer.push({
    'event': 'purchase',
    'ecommerce': {
      'transaction_id': '{{ order.order_number }}',
      'value': {{ checkout.total_price | money_without_currency | remove:
        ',' }},
      'currency': '{{ shop.currency }}',
      'items': [
        {% for line_item in order.line_items %}
        {
          'item_id': '{{ line_item.product_id }}',
          'item_name': '{{ line_item.title | escape }}',
          'item_variant': '{{ line_item.variant.title | escape }}',
          'price': {{ line_item.price | money_without_currency | remove:
        ',' }},
          'quantity': {{ line_item.quantity }}
        }{% unless forloop.last %},{% endunless %}
        {% endfor %}
      ]
    }
  });
</script>
```

Step 4: Configure GA4 in GTM

1. In GTM → **Tags → New**
2. Click **Tag Configuration** → **Google Analytics: GA4 Configuration**
3. Enter your GA4 Measurement ID (G-XXXXXXXXXX)
4. Under **Triggering**, select **All Pages**
5. Name the tag "GA4 — Configuration"
6. Click **Save**

Step 5: Set Up Ecommerce Event Tags

For each ecommerce event (add_to_cart, begin_checkout, purchase), you'll need a tag that reads from the dataLayer and sends to GA4. This is an advanced topic — if you're not comfortable with GTM, consider using Method 1 or hiring someone to complete this step.

> **Tip:** The Google Analytics Debugger Chrome extension is invaluable for testing GTM setups. Install it, enable it, and you'll see exactly which events are firing and what data they contain.

Step 6: Publish Your GTM Container

1. In GTM, click **Submit** (top right)
2. Add a version name (e.g., "Initial GA4 Setup")
3. Click **Publish**

Nothing in GTM goes live until you publish. If you make changes and forget to publish, nothing will change on your site.

Method 3: Manual Script (Avoid If Possible)

Manually adding the GA4 tracking code to your theme works, but it's the least flexible option. You can't manage events from a central place, it's harder to debug, and it breaks more easily with theme updates.

If you must go manual:

1. In GA4 → **Admin → Data Streams** → click your stream
2. Click **View tag instructions**
3. Copy the Global Site Tag (gtag.js) code
4. In Shopify Admin → **Online Store → Themes → Edit code**
5. In `theme.liquid`, paste the tag immediately after `<head>`
6. Save

For purchase tracking, use the Additional Scripts method described in the GTM section above.

Verifying Your Shopify → GA4 Connection

After setup, verify these four things work:

1. Session tracking works Open your store. Check GA4 Realtime. You appear as an active user.

2. Product views track Visit a product page. In GA4 Realtime → Event count, you should see `view_item`.

3. Add to cart tracks Add a product to cart. Look for `add_to_cart` in Realtime.

4. Purchase tracks Place a test order (using Shopify's Bogus Gateway: Settings → Payments → Test mode). Look for `purchase` in Realtime with revenue data.

If any of these fail, don't move on. Fix the foundation first.

Part 2: The 5 Reports Every Shopify Owner Needs

Once your tracking is working, here's what to actually look at.

These five reports cover the questions that matter for a Shopify store. Each one tells you something actionable. Each one is something you can build in GA4 without a paid tool.

Report 1: Revenue by Channel

The question it answers: Where is my money actually coming from?

This is your most important report. It shows revenue broken down by traffic source — paid search, organic search, email, social, direct, and referral.

Building the Report in GA4

1. Go to **Reports → Monetisation → Ecommerce Purchases**
2. At the top, click **+ Add comparison** or change the primary dimension
3. Alternatively: Go to **Explore** (the compass icon in the left nav)

Building a custom Revenue by Channel Exploration:

1. Click **Explore → Blank**
2. Name it "Revenue by Channel"
3. In **Dimensions**, click **+** and add:
    - `Session default channel group`
    - `Session source / medium`

4. In **Metrics**, click **+** and add:
    - `Total revenue`
    - `Transactions`
    - `Average purchase revenue`
    - `Sessions`
    - `Session conversion rate`
5. Drag **Session default channel group** to the **Rows** box
6. Drag all metrics to the **Values** box
7. Set date range to last 30 days

You now have a table showing every channel, how much revenue it generated, how many transactions, average order value, and conversion rate.

How to Read This Report

COLUMN	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Total Revenue	Gross revenue attributed to this channel
Transactions	Number of completed orders
Avg Purchase Revenue	Average order value per channel
Sessions	Total sessions from this channel
Session Conversion Rate	% of sessions from this channel that resulted in a purchase

What you're looking for:

- Which channel generates the most revenue? (Usually email for established stores, paid search for newer ones)
- Which channel has the highest conversion rate? (Usually email — people who sign up already trust you)
- Which channel sends a lot of traffic but converts poorly? (Often display ads or broad social)

- Which channel has a surprisingly high average order value? (Often branded search — people who Google your name are often ready to buy)

Common Misreads

"Direct" traffic is massive — This often means attribution is broken somewhere. Direct traffic = sessions where GA4 can't identify a source. If you're seeing 40%+ of revenue attributed to "direct," check your referral exclusions and UTM parameter setup.

"Paid Search" shows zero — If you're running Google Ads and seeing no paid search revenue, your Google Ads link is broken or auto-tagging is disabled. Fix this before interpreting any other paid channel data.

Email shows as "referral" — This means your email links aren't tagged with UTM parameters. See the UTM section in Part 4.

Setting Up Channel Groupings

GA4 has default channel groupings, but they don't always match how you think about your marketing. You can customise channel groups:

1. In Admin → **Data Settings** → **Channel groups**
2. Click **Create new channel group**
3. Define rules that match your business (e.g., create an "Organic Social" group that includes Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, LinkedIn)

Report 2: Customer Acquisition Cost

The question it answers: How much does it cost to get a new customer from each channel?

This is the report most small business owners never build — and the one that would change their marketing decisions more than anything else.

Customer acquisition cost (CAC) is simple in theory:

CAC = Channel Spend ÷ New Customers from that Channel

In practice, it requires pulling data from multiple places.

Building the CAC Report

GA4 alone can't give you this. You need to combine data from: - **GA4** (new users and transactions by channel) - **Google Ads** (spend by campaign) - **Shopify** (total orders and first-time vs returning customers)

Step 1: Get new customer counts by channel from GA4

1. In **Explore → Blank**
2. Add dimension: `Session default channel group`
3. Add metrics: `New users`, `Transactions`, `Total revenue`
4. Drag to visualisation
5. Filter: Add a segment for **New Users** (under Segments → User segment → First visit users)
6. Export as CSV or note the numbers

Step 2: Get spend data from Google Ads

In Google Ads: 1. Go to **Campaigns** 2. Set date range to match your GA4 date range 3. Note spend by campaign type (branded search, non-branded search, shopping, performance max)

Step 3: Calculate CAC

Build this simple table (in a spreadsheet or in your notes):

CHANNEL	SPEND	NEW CUSTOMERS	CAC
Google Ads — Branded	$800	45	$17.78
Google Ads — Non-Branded	$2,400	32	$75.00
Organic Search	$0	67	$0
Email	$200 (tool cost)	28	$7.14
Paid Social	$1,200	18	$66.67

(Numbers are illustrative — your store will vary)

What Does a Good CAC Look Like?

CAC only makes sense in relation to your **Customer Lifetime Value (CLV)**.

A basic CLV calculation:

CLV = Average Order Value × Average Orders Per Year × Average Customer Lifespan (years)

If your average customer spends $180 and orders 2.5 times per year and stays for 2 years: **CLV = $180 × 2.5 × 2 = $900**

A CAC of $75 against a CLV of $900 is a healthy 12:1 LTV:CAC ratio. A CAC of $450 against the same CLV is a problem.

> **Rule of thumb:** Aim for LTV:CAC of at least 3:1 for a sustainable business. Under 1:1 means you're losing money acquiring customers. Over 5:1 usually means you're under-investing in acquisition and leaving growth on the table.

Tracking CLV in Shopify

Shopify Analytics has a built-in Customer reports section:

1. In Shopify Admin → **Analytics → Reports**

2. Under **Customers**, look for:
    - **Customers over time** — new vs returning
    - **Returning customers** — who came back and what they spent
    - **One-time customers** — who hasn't returned (retention opportunity)

For deeper CLV analysis, Shopify's **Cohort Analysis** report (available on some plans) shows how different customer acquisition cohorts behave over time.

Report 3: Top Landing Pages

The question it answers: Which pages are bringing in revenue-ready visitors?

Not all entry points are equal. Someone who lands on a specific product page is much closer to buying than someone who lands on your blog. This report shows which pages are the best "front doors" for revenue.

Building the Report in GA4

1. Go to **Explore → Blank**
2. Name it "Landing Page Revenue"
3. Add dimension: `Landing page + query string`
4. Add metrics:
    - `Sessions`
    - `Transactions`
    - `Total revenue`
    - `Session conversion rate`
    - `Bounce rate`
5. Sort by **Total Revenue** descending
6. Set to show top 50 rows

How to Read This Report

High sessions, low conversion rate: The page is attracting traffic but not converting it. Check the page experience — is there a clear CTA? Is the product priced correctly? Are there reviews?

Low sessions, high conversion rate: A high-converting page that not enough people see. This is a growth opportunity — drive more traffic to this page (SEO, ads, email feature).

High bounce rate on product pages: Visitors are leaving immediately. Usually means the page doesn't match what they expected (ad creative mismatch, slow load time, or the product isn't what they searched for).

Home page dominates revenue: This is common for direct and branded traffic, but if your home page accounts for 60%+ of revenue and product pages are weak, your collection and product page experience needs work.

Segmenting by Channel

To see which landing pages perform best for a specific channel:

1. In your Exploration, click **+ Add segment** at the top
2. Create a segment: **Session default channel group = Paid Search**
3. Now you see which landing pages your Google Ads traffic hits — and how those pages convert

This helps you align your ad landing pages with your highest-converting pages.

Page Speed and Landing Page Performance

Slow pages kill conversions. Google's own research suggests each second of load time after 3 seconds reduces conversions by approximately 7%.

Check your landing page speeds: 1. Go to pagespeed.web.dev 2. Enter each of your top landing pages 3. Focus on **Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)** — should be under 2.5 seconds 4. Note any "Opportunities" listed — these are specific fixes

> **Shopify tip:** Compressed images are the single biggest lever for Shopify page speed. If your images are larger than 500KB, compress them with TinyPNG or use Shopify's built-in image compression. A single unoptimised hero image can add 3-4 seconds to your load time.

Report 4: Cart Abandonment Funnel

The question it answers: Where exactly are people dropping off before they buy?

Cart abandonment is one of the biggest revenue recovery opportunities in ecommerce. The industry average cart abandonment rate is around 70% — meaning 7 in 10 people who add something to cart never complete the purchase.

But "cart abandonment" is actually multiple steps, and the drop-off usually happens at a specific point. This report shows where.

Building the Funnel in GA4

1. Go to **Explore → Funnel Exploration**
2. Name it "Purchase Funnel"
3. Under **Steps**, click **Edit pencil**
4. Add the following steps in order:
   - **Step 1:** Event name = `view_item` (Name: "Viewed Product")
   - **Step 2:** Event name = `add_to_cart` (Name: "Added to Cart")
   - **Step 3:** Event name = `begin_checkout` (Name: "Started Checkout")
   - **Step 4:** Event name = `add_payment_info` (Name: "Entered Payment")
   - **Step 5:** Event name = `purchase` (Name: "Completed Purchase")
5. Set funnel type to **Open** (allows users to enter at any step)
6. Set date range to last 30 days

Reading the Funnel

The funnel will show you the drop-off percentage at each step. Here's what the numbers typically mean:

View Item → Add to Cart (typical range: 3-12%) Low add-to-cart rate: Product pages aren't compelling enough. Check: Are prices competitive? Are there reviews? Is the product photography good? Is the size/variant selector confusing?

Add to Cart → Begin Checkout (typical range: 25-50%) High drop-off here: Customers are getting stalled at the cart. Check: Is the cart page cluttered? Are there unexpected shipping costs shown? Does the cart page show clearly what's in the bag?

Begin Checkout → Add Payment Info (typical range: 50-80%) Drop-off here: Customers are balking at the checkout form. Check: Is guest checkout available? How many form fields are required? Are there trust signals (SSL, payment badges)?

Add Payment Info → Purchase (typical range: 60-90%) Drop-off here: Technical issues or price shock. Check: Are all payment methods working? Is there a payment processing error? Are there hidden fees appearing at the final step?

Building a Segment Comparison

Run the funnel twice with different segments to understand who's abandoning vs completing:

- **Segment 1:** New users only
- **Segment 2:** Returning users only

Returning users almost always have a better funnel conversion rate. If the gap is huge (e.g., new users convert at 0.8% and returning users at 4.2%), it suggests trust is the barrier — new visitors don't believe in you yet.

Acting on Funnel Data

The most effective cart abandonment interventions are:

1. **Abandoned cart emails** — Shopify includes basic abandoned cart emails. Klaviyo makes them much more powerful. An email sent 1 hour after abandonment typically recovers 5-10% of abandoned carts.
2. **Exit-intent popups** — Triggered when a user moves their mouse toward the browser tab/close button. Offer a discount code or remind them what's in their cart.
3. **Retargeting ads** — Show ads to people who visited your product pages or added to cart but didn't buy. Google Ads and Meta both support this.
4. **Checkout friction reduction** — Review every field in your checkout. Remove anything non-essential. Enable Shop Pay, Google Pay, and Apple Pay for one-click checkout.

Report 5: Return Customer Rate

The question it answers: Are people coming back?

A store that's only acquiring new customers is on a treadmill. Every month you need to spend money to bring in new buyers just to stay still. A healthy ecommerce business has a growing base of repeat customers who buy without paid acquisition.

Return customer rate is the metric that tells you whether your post-purchase experience is strong enough to earn repeat business.

Getting Return Customer Data

GA4 doesn't have a perfect out-of-the-box "return customer" report, but you can build a close approximation.

Method 1: Shopify's Native Report

Shopify tracks first-time vs returning customers natively:

1. In Shopify Admin → **Analytics → Reports**
2. Open **Returning customers** report
3. You'll see: orders from new customers, orders from returning customers, and the split over time

What's a healthy return rate?

BUSINESS TYPE	HEALTHY RETURN RATE
Fashion / Apparel	20-30%
Beauty / Personal Care	30-45%
Home & Garden	15-25%
Food & Consumables	40-60%
Gifts / Novelty	10-20%

If your return rate is below these ranges, you have a retention problem.

Method 2: GA4 New vs Returning Users

1. In GA4 → **Reports → User → User attributes → Returning users**
2. Or in Explore, add dimension `New / Returning` and segment by transaction

This shows the revenue split between new and returning users, though it's less precise than Shopify's data because GA4 uses cookies for identification (which can break across devices or browsers).

Building a Cohort Report in GA4

GA4's cohort analysis shows you how well you retain users over time.

1. Go to **Explore → Cohort Exploration**
2. Set **Cohort inclusion:** `First touch — first_visit`
3. Set **Return criteria:** `Any event — any event` OR `purchase`
4. Set **Cohort granularity:** Weekly or Monthly

This shows you: of users who first visited in Week 1, what percentage came back in Week 2, Week 3, Week 4?

A healthy ecommerce store sees retention plateaus — the curve flattens rather than dropping to zero. If your Week 4+ retention is near zero, customers are buying once and never returning.

Using RFM Analysis

For stores with more than 200 total customers, RFM (Recency, Frequency, Monetary) analysis is the gold standard for understanding your customer base.

RFM segments customers into groups based on: - **Recency:** How recently did they last buy? - **Frequency:** How many times have they bought? - **Monetary:** How much have they spent total?

This creates segments like: - **Champions** — Bought recently, buys often, high value - **Loyal Customers** — Regular buyers, not the highest spend - **At Risk** — Used to buy regularly, haven't bought in a while - **Lost Customers** — Bought once or twice, a long time ago

Shopify doesn't build RFM natively, but several apps do (including Klaviyo's segment builder). The Bonus Checklist at the back of this guide includes an RFM quick-start.

Part 3: Your Weekly Analytics Ritual

The most valuable analytics habit isn't a complex dashboard or a two-hour analysis session. It's a consistent 15-minute check every week.

Here's exactly how to run it.

Why Weekly?

Daily is too noisy. Ecommerce traffic fluctuates day to day — a Tuesday slowdown doesn't mean your business is dying, it means it's Tuesday.

Monthly is too infrequent. You'll only notice problems after four weeks, by which time you've left money on the table for a month.

Weekly gives you enough data to spot real trends, enough frequency to catch problems early, and enough distance from daily noise to see signal instead of static.

The 15-Minute Weekly Check

Set aside the same time every week. Monday morning works well for most store owners — you're reviewing the previous week with fresh eyes, and you have the week ahead to act on what you find.

Minutes 1-3: Revenue Check

Where to look: Shopify Analytics → Overview

What to check: - This week's total revenue vs last week - This week's total orders vs last week - Average order value — up or down?

Question to ask yourself: Is the direction of change what I expected, given anything that happened this week (sale, email send, new campaign)?

If revenue is down significantly and you can't explain why, that's your first investigation.

Minutes 4-6: Channel Performance

Where to look: GA4 → Reports → Acquisition → Traffic acquisition

What to check: - Which channel sent the most sessions? - Which channel had the best conversion rate? - Has anything changed dramatically from last week?

Red flags to look for: - Paid search conversions suddenly drop to zero (Google Ads problem or tracking break) - "Direct" traffic spikes unusually (attribution broken somewhere) - A channel that was contributing revenue disappears

---

Minutes 7-9: Top Products

Where to look: GA4 → Reports → Monetisation → Ecommerce Purchases

What to check: - Which products sold most this week? - Any products that usually sell well that had a quiet week? - Any products punching above their weight (selling more than expected)?

Unusual product performance is often explained by: a feature in an email, an organic mention somewhere, a competitor out of stock, or a seasonal spike.

Minutes 10-11: Funnel Check

Where to look: Your saved Funnel Exploration in GA4

What to check: - Has any step in the funnel changed by more than 5 percentage points?

A sudden drop in the add_to_cart → begin_checkout rate often signals a technical problem (checkout button broken, page load issue) rather than a marketing problem. Technical problems need immediate investigation.

Minutes 12-13: Paid Ads Quick Scan (if running ads)

Where to look: Google Ads → Overview

What to check: - Total spend for the week - Conversions recorded in Google Ads - Any campaigns with unusually high spend and zero conversions

A campaign spending money with no conversions is the most common money-drain in ecommerce Google Ads. It should be caught weekly, not monthly.

Minute 14-15: Note One Action

At the end of every weekly check, write down **one specific action** based on what you've seen. Not five actions — one.

Examples: - "Product X had a great week — add it to the featured section on home page" - "Conversion rate from paid social is 0.2% — pause campaigns under $5 ROAS" - "Checkout to payment step dropped 15% — check Afterpay integration is working" - "Email drove the most revenue again — brief email team to send one more campaign this month"

One action, implemented. That's what separates the analytics review from being a passive exercise.

Your Weekly Ritual Template

Copy this into a note or spreadsheet and fill it in each week:

```
WEEKLY ANALYTICS CHECK — [DATE]

REVENUE
- This week: $______
- Last week: $______
- Change: ___% | Explain: _______________

CHANNEL SNAPSHOT
- Top channel by revenue: _______________
- Top channel by conversion rate: _______________
- Anything unusual: _______________

TOP PRODUCTS
- #1: _______________ ($_____)
- #2: _______________ ($_____)
- #3: _______________ ($_____)

FUNNEL CHECK
- Any drop-off anomaly? Y / N
- If yes, where: _______________

PAID ADS (if applicable)
- Total spend: $_____
- Total conversions: _____
- Any dead campaigns? _______________

THIS WEEK'S ONE ACTION:
_____
```

Print this out. Put it next to your keyboard. Do it every week without fail.

Monthly Deep Dive (1 hour/month)

Once a month, go deeper. This is where you spot longer-term trends.

Monthly deep dive checklist:

- [ ] Compare this month to same month last year
- [ ]

- [ ] Review CAC by channel (update your CAC spreadsheet)
- [ ] Review return customer rate — is it trending up or down?
- [ ] Review top landing pages — any new pages performing well?
- [ ] Review cohort retention — how are last month's new customers behaving?
- [ ] Check Search Console — any ranking changes to top pages?
- [ ] Review Google Ads — which campaigns are above/below target ROAS?
- [ ] Check for tracking issues — do GA4 and Shopify revenue numbers roughly agree? (within 10-15% is normal; more than 20% apart needs investigation)

The monthly review takes longer, but once a month is manageable even for time-poor business owners.

Part 4: Google Ads + Search Console Integration

GA4 alone tells you how your website performs. Connected to Google Ads and Search Console, it tells you whether your marketing is working.

This section covers how to set up and use both integrations properly.

Google Search Console: Setup and Integration

Search Console shows you your presence in Google's organic search results. It's free, it's essential, and it's underused by almost every small business.

Setting Up Search Console

1. Go to **search.google.com/search-console**
2. Click **Add property**
3. Choose **Domain** (not URL prefix — Domain gives you more complete data)
4. Enter your domain: `yourstore.com.au`
5. Follow the DNS verification steps:
    - Copy the TXT record provided
    - Log into your domain registrar (GoDaddy, Namecheap, Cloudflare, etc.)
    - Add the TXT record to your DNS settings
    - Return to Search Console and click **Verify**
6. DNS verification can take 24-72 hours to propagate

Add all domain variants:

Once your main domain is verified, add these as properties too: - `https://yourstore.com.au` - `https://www.yourstore.com.au`

Google treats these as separate properties. Connecting all variants ensures you see complete data.

Submitting Your Sitemap

Your sitemap tells Google what pages exist on your site.

Shopify automatically generates a sitemap at: `https://yourstore.com.au/sitemap.xml`

Submit it to Search Console: 1. In Search Console → **Indexing → Sitemaps** 2. Paste your sitemap URL: `yourstore.com.au/sitemap.xml` 3. Click **Submit**

After submission, Google will crawl your sitemap and start indexing your pages. Check back after a few days to see how many pages are indexed vs submitted.

The Three Search Console Reports You Need

1. Performance Report — What's Bringing People to Your Site

Go to: Search Console → **Performance → Search results**

Set the date range to last 3 months. You'll see: - **Total clicks** — actual visits from search - **Total impressions** — how many times your pages appeared in results - **Average CTR** — click-through rate (clicks ÷ impressions) - **Average position** — your average ranking position

Sort by Clicks to see your best-performing queries. These are the keywords already working for you.

Sort by Impressions with a filter for CTR < 3% to find opportunities: pages that appear in search but rarely get clicked. Improving the title tag and meta description for these pages can drive more traffic without any ranking improvement.

2. Index Coverage — What Google Can (and Can't) See

Go to: Search Console → **Indexing → Pages**

This shows: - **Indexed pages** — pages Google has indexed - **Not indexed pages** — pages Google found but didn't index (and why)

Common "not indexed" reasons for Shopify stores: - **Crawled - currently not indexed:** Google crawled the page but chose not to index it (often thin content pages like tag pages) - **Duplicate, Google chose different canonical:** You have two URLs for the same content; Google chose one - **Page with redirect:** A page that redirects somewhere else — not a problem unless pages you want indexed are redirecting

3. Core Web Vitals — Your Page Experience Score

Go to: Search Console → **Experience → Core Web Vitals**

This shows which pages pass or fail Google's page experience metrics: - **Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)** — load speed - **Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)** — visual stability (things jumping around) - **Interaction to Next Paint (INP)** — responsiveness to clicks/taps

Pages that fail Core Web Vitals are penalised in rankings. For Shopify stores, the most common failure is LCP on image-heavy product pages.

Reading Search Console Data in GA4

Once Search Console is linked to GA4:

1. In GA4 → **Reports → Acquisition → Search Console**
2. You'll see two reports:
    - **Google organic search queries** — which keywords drive traffic and how they behave on site
    - **Google organic search traffic** — landing pages from organic search with engagement data

These reports are powerful because they combine Search Console's visibility data (impressions, CTR, position) with GA4's behaviour data (bounce rate, conversion rate, revenue). You can see which organic keywords are not just driving traffic, but driving purchasing visitors.

Google Ads Integration

If you're spending money on Google Ads, proper integration with GA4 is not optional — it's the only way to know whether your spend is profitable.

Linking Google Ads to GA4 (If Not Done in Setup)

1. In GA4 Admin → **Property Links → Google Ads Links**
2. Click **Link**
3. Select your Google Ads account from the list
4. Enable **Enable auto-tagging** (critical)
5. Enable **Import Google Analytics conversions into Google Ads** (optional but recommended)
6. Click **Submit**

Setting Up Conversion Tracking in Google Ads

There are two ways to import conversions into Google Ads from GA4:

Option A: Import GA4 Conversions (Recommended)

1. In Google Ads → **Tools → Conversions**
2. Click **New conversion action**
3. Select **Import → Google Analytics 4 properties**
4. Select your GA4 property
5. Select the conversion events to import (select `purchase`)
6. Click **Import and continue**

Now Google Ads can optimise your campaigns based on purchase data from GA4.

Option B: Direct Google Ads Conversion Tag

Alternatively, install the Google Ads conversion tag directly on your order confirmation page. This gives Google Ads its own conversion tracking, independent of GA4.

If you're using GTM, add the Conversion Linker tag (fires on all pages) and a Google Ads Conversion Tracking tag (fires on the order confirmation page).

> **Which should you use?** Start with GA4 import. It's simpler and shares the same data source as your reporting. If you're running high-spend campaigns and need the most accurate bidding data, add the direct tag as well — having both doesn't cause problems.

Setting Up Conversion Value Rules

Google Ads' smart bidding works better when it understands the value of different conversions. Set this up:

1. In Google Ads → **Tools → Conversions**
2. Click on your purchase conversion action
3. Under **Value**, select **Use conversion values from each transaction**
4. This tells Google Ads to use the actual order value from each transaction rather than a fixed value

With this set up, Target ROAS (Return on Ad Spend) bidding can optimise toward higher-value orders, not just any order.

Google Ads Reports to Watch in GA4

Once connected, GA4 provides several Google Ads reports:

1. Google Ads Campaigns (Reports → Acquisition → Google Ads → Campaigns)

Shows: Clicks, sessions, conversions, and revenue by campaign. Compare this to your Google Ads dashboard for sanity checking.

2. Google Ads Keywords (Reports → Acquisition → Google Ads → Google Ads Keywords)

Shows: Which keywords are driving sessions and conversions. Essential for keyword-level ROAS analysis.

3. Google Ads Queries (Reports → Acquisition → Google Ads → Google Ads Search Queries)

Shows: The actual search terms users typed before clicking your ads. This is different from your keywords — keywords are what you're bidding on, queries are what people actually searched. This report identifies negative keyword opportunities (search terms triggering your ads that aren't relevant).

UTM Parameters: The Missing Piece

UTM parameters are tags you add to URLs to tell GA4 exactly where traffic came from. They're essential for any traffic source where GA4 can't automatically identify the source — primarily email and social media.

The five UTM parameters:

PARAMETER	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLE
`utm_source`	The referrer	`klaviyo`, `facebook`, `newsletter`
`utm_medium`	The marketing medium	`email`, `social`, `cpc`
`utm_campaign`	The specific campaign	`spring-sale-2025`, `cart-abandonment`
`utm_content`	Specific link/creative (optional)	`hero-banner`, `text-link`
`utm_term`	Search keyword (optional, usually for ads)	`shopify-seo`

Building UTM-tagged URLs:

Use Google's Campaign URL Builder: **ga-dev-tools.google/campaign-url-builder**

Example for a promotional email:

```
https://yourstore.com.au/collections/sale?
utm_source=klaviyo&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=black-
friday-2025&utm_content=header-banner
```

Where you must use UTM parameters: - All links in marketing emails - All links in social media posts (where auto-tagging isn't available) - All links in any SMS campaigns - Links in any partnerships or affiliate arrangements - Links in any press mentions where you can provide the URL

Where you don't need UTM parameters: - Google Ads links (auto-tagging handles this) - Organic social (you can't add UTMs to organic posts in a way that helps GA4) - Internal links (never add UTMs to links within your own site — it breaks attribution)

> **Warning:** Never add UTM parameters to internal links on your website. If you link from your blog to your shop with UTM parameters, every time someone clicks that link, GA4 treats it as a new session from a new source — completely destroying your attribution data.

Setting Up a UTM Naming Convention

Consistency is everything with UTMs. If your emails sometimes use `utm_source=email` and sometimes `utm_source=klaviyo`, they'll appear as two different channels in GA4.

Create a simple naming convention document and share it with anyone who creates marketing links:

```
SOURCES:
- Email: klaviyo
- Facebook: facebook
- Instagram: instagram
- TikTok: tiktok
- LinkedIn: linkedin
- SMS: sms

MEDIUMS:
- Email: email
```

```
- Social paid: cpc
- Social organic: social
- SMS: sms
- Partnership: referral

CAMPAIGNS:
- Format: [campaign-name]-[year]
- Example: spring-sale-2025, welcome-series-2025, cart-abandonment-2025
- Use lowercase, hyphens not underscores
```

7. Reading the Numbers — What's Good, What's a Red Flag

Analytics without benchmarks is just numbers. Here's the context you need to know whether your store is performing well or poorly.

These benchmarks are drawn from Australian ecommerce data and general Shopify industry figures for 2024-2025. Your mileage will vary based on product category, price point, and audience — treat these as starting guides, not gospel.

Traffic Benchmarks

Session Volume

There's no universal "right" number for sessions, but rough guides for small ecommerce stores:

STAGE	MONTHLY SESSIONS	CONTEXT
Getting Started	< 1,000	Focus on product-market fit before scaling traffic
Growing	1,000–10,000	Testing channels, finding what works
Established	10,000–50,000	Clear channel mix, scaling what works
Mature	50,000+	Multi-channel machine, optimisation focus

Traffic Source Mix (Healthy Store)

CHANNEL	TYPICAL RANGE	NOTES
Organic Search	25–45%	Higher is better — reduces paid dependency
Direct	10–20%	Very high direct often means attribution gaps
Paid Search	10–30%	Depends on ad spend
Email	10–25%	Grows over time as list builds
Paid Social	5–20%	Depends on social strategy
Referral	2–10%	Affiliates, press, partnerships
Organic Social	1–8%	Lower than most expect

If your traffic is 80%+ direct, you have an attribution problem. If your traffic is 90%+ paid, you have a risk problem (turn off ads, revenue disappears).

Conversion Rate Benchmarks

Overall Shopify conversion rate (sessions to purchase):

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	CONVERSION RATE
Poor	< 0.5%
Average	1–2%
Good	2–3.5%
Excellent	3.5%+

By channel:

CHANNEL	TYPICAL CONVERSION RATE
Email	3–7%
Direct	2–5%
Branded Search (paid)	3–8%
Organic Search	1–3%
Non-Branded Paid Search	0.8–2.5%
Paid Social	0.5–2%
Organic Social	0.3–1%
Display/Retargeting	0.5–2%

> **Important context:** Conversion rate is highly sensitive to price point. A $15 product should convert at 3-5%+. A $500 product converting at 0.8% may actually be excellent. Compare yourself to stores with similar price points.

Funnel Benchmarks

FUNNEL STEP	TYPICAL RATE
View Item → Add to Cart	5–15%
Add to Cart → Begin Checkout	30–60%
Begin Checkout → Purchase	50–80%
Overall: View Item → Purchase	1–5%

Cart abandonment rate (industry average: ~70%)

A 30% cart completion rate is roughly average. Stores with frictionless checkout (Shop Pay, guest checkout, no surprise fees) achieve 40–50% cart completion.

Average Order Value Benchmarks

AOV varies enormously by product, but:

CATEGORY	TYPICAL AOV (AUD)
Fashion / Apparel	$90–$160
Beauty / Skincare	$60–$120
Home / Garden	$80–$180
Electronics accessories	$40–$100
Food / Beverage	$50–$90
Sporting Goods	$100–$200
Gifts / Novelty	$50–$80

AOV strategies: product bundles, free shipping thresholds, volume discounts, and post-purchase upsells all lift AOV without requiring more traffic.

Email Benchmarks

METRIC	AVERAGE (ECOMMERCE)	GOOD
Open rate	25–35%	40%+
Click rate	2–5%	6%+
Conversion rate (click → purchase)	2–5%	7%+
Unsubscribe rate	< 0.3%	< 0.1%
Revenue per email sent	$0.05–$0.15	$0.20+

Google Ads Benchmarks

ROAS (Return on Ad Spend)

ROAS = Revenue ÷ Spend. A 4x ROAS means you generate $4 in revenue for every $1 spent.

PERFORMANCE	ROAS
Breaking even (depends on margins)	2–3x
Profitable (moderate margin)	4–6x
Strong	6–10x
Excellent	10x+

> **ROAS is not profit.** A 4x ROAS on a product with 20% margin is still losing money. Calculate your break-even ROAS:
> **Break-even ROAS = 1 ÷ Gross Margin**
> Example: 40% margin → break-even ROAS = 2.5x

Target ROAS by campaign type:

CAMPAIGN TYPE	REALISTIC TARGET
Branded Search	8–20x (usually your best ROAS)
Shopping / Product Listing	3–7x
Non-Branded Search	3–6x
Performance Max	3–6x
Retargeting	5–12x
Display Prospecting	1–3x

Click-Through Rate

CAMPAIGN TYPE	AVERAGE CTR	GOOD CTR
Search	3–6%	8%+
Shopping	1–3%	4%+
Display	0.3–0.5%	1%+

Quality Score

Google Ads Quality Score (1-10) affects your ad rank and costs.

SCORE	STATUS
1–3	Poor — investigate immediately
4–6	Average — room for improvement
7–9	Good — maintain and test improvements
10	Excellent — rarely achievable, rarely necessary

Search Console Benchmarks

METRIC	AVERAGE	GOOD
Organic CTR (position 1)	25–30%	35%+
Organic CTR (position 3)	10–12%	15%+
Organic CTR (position 10)	2–3%	4%+
Index coverage rate	80–95%	95%+
Core Web Vitals (pass rate)	—	90%+

Red Flag Indicators

Stop and investigate immediately if you see any of these:

🚨 **GA4 revenue is more than 25% below Shopify revenue** — tracking is missing transactions

🚨 **Conversion rate suddenly drops 50%+ week on week** — checkout is broken or a key page is broken

🚨 **"Direct" traffic suddenly becomes 60%+ of total** — attribution has broken somewhere

🚨 **Google Ads spend is up but conversions are zero** — conversion tracking has broken

🚨 **Organic search traffic drops 30%+ month on month** — Google algorithm update, manual penalty, or indexing issue

🚨 **Bounce rate on product pages suddenly spikes to 90%+** — page may have an error or extremely slow load

🚨 **Revenue from email drops to near zero** — email platform might be having issues or your unsubscribe rate spiked

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8. Automating Your Reporting

Weekly manual checks are valuable. But some things are worth automating — either to save time, or to catch problems you might not spot in your weekly review.

Free Automation Options

GA4 Email Snapshots

GA4 can email you a report summary on a schedule:

1. Open any standard report in GA4
2. Click the **Share** icon (top right of the report)
3. Select **Schedule email**
4. Set frequency (daily, weekly, monthly)
5. Enter your email address
6. Click **Schedule**

Recommended scheduled reports: - **Weekly:** Traffic Acquisition (Monday morning) - **Weekly:** Ecommerce Purchases (Monday morning) - **Monthly:** User Acquisition (first day of month)

GA4 Custom Alerts (Annotations)

GA4 doesn't have the same alert system as Universal Analytics, but you can use Looker Studio (free) for alerts. However, for quick anomaly detection:

1. In GA4 → **Explore**
2. Build a key metrics exploration
3. **Share → Get link**

4. Save this link — it's your quick-access dashboard

Google Looker Studio (Free Dashboards)

Looker Studio (formerly Google Data Studio) is Google's free dashboard tool. It connects to GA4, Google Ads, Search Console, and many other sources to build custom dashboards that update automatically.

Setting up a Looker Studio dashboard:

1. Go to **lookerstudio.google.com**
2. Click **Create → Report**
3. Connect your GA4 property as a data source
4. Start with a **Blank** template or browse the **Template Gallery** for ecommerce templates

Recommended Looker Studio report structure:

Page 1: Executive Overview - Total revenue (scorecard) - Total orders (scorecard) - Average order value (scorecard) - Conversion rate (scorecard) - Revenue by day (time series chart) - Revenue by channel (bar chart)

Page 2: Acquisition Deep Dive - Sessions by channel (table with conversion rate) - New vs returning users - Top traffic sources (detailed table)

Page 3: Product Performance - Top products by revenue - Top products by quantity - Product conversion rates

Page 4: Google Ads Performance (if running ads) - Spend vs Revenue vs ROAS - Campaign performance table - Keyword performance

Looker Studio tips: - Use **date range controls** so you can easily change the date range without rebuilding the report - Use **comparison date ranges** to show change vs previous period - Add **report-level filters** to quickly segment by channel or country - Share the report via link with your team — no GA4 access required

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Shopify Email Digests

Shopify sends automated email digests with revenue summaries:

1. In Shopify Admin → **Settings → Notifications**
2. Enable daily and/or weekly report emails

These give you a plain-English revenue summary without needing to log in.

Google Sheets with GA4 API (Advanced)

For more custom automation, you can pull GA4 data directly into Google Sheets using the GA4 connector:

1. In Google Sheets, go to **Extensions → Add-ons → Get add-ons**
2. Search for **"Google Analytics"** — install the official Google Add-on
3. Open it from **Extensions → Google Analytics**
4. Build a query: select your property, dimensions, metrics, and date range
5. Click **Run Reports**
6. Set up a **Schedule** to run automatically (daily, weekly)

This gives you raw data in a spreadsheet that you can use for custom analysis, charts, or feeding into other tools.

Paid Automation Options

Once you're serious about analytics and spending meaningful amounts on ads, these paid tools become worth considering:

Northbeam ($500–$2,000+/month)

Best for: High-spend multi-channel advertisers who need sophisticated attribution

Northbeam builds a comprehensive multi-touch attribution model that goes beyond last-click. It pulls data from all your advertising channels, your email platform, and your Shopify store and gives you a unified view of every customer touchpoint.

When to consider it: When you're spending $30,000+/month across multiple paid channels and you need to confidently answer "which channel is actually driving revenue?"

Triple Whale (~$250/month for most stores)

Best for: Shopify-focused brands who want a simplified analytics dashboard with good attribution

Triple Whale is built specifically for Shopify. It connects to Meta, Google, TikTok, and other platforms and provides simplified ROAS reporting and attribution. More affordable than Northbeam and easier to set up.

When to consider it: When you're spending $5,000+/month on paid ads and the native platform dashboards are confusing you.

Littledata ($99/month)

Best for: Fixing GA4 accuracy problems without complex setup

Littledata is a Shopify app that improves GA4 and Klaviyo data accuracy by server-side tracking — it doesn't rely on the browser, so ad-blocked sessions still get recorded. It also improves cross-device attribution.

When to consider it: When GA4 revenue is more than 20% below Shopify revenue consistently.

This is often a faster, cheaper fix than debugging a broken GTM setup manually.

Klaviyo Analytics (Included with Klaviyo)

If you're already using Klaviyo for email, use its built-in analytics:

- Email revenue attribution
- Flow performance (automations vs campaigns)
- Per-email revenue
- Segment performance

Klaviyo's attribution model is "last-click, 5-day window" — meaning it attributes a purchase to an email if the customer clicked that email within the last 5 days. This is more conservative than some tools and generally reliable.

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9. Common Tracking Mistakes That Cost You Money

These are the mistakes we see most often when we audit Shopify stores. Each one is costing someone money right now. Check every one against your own setup.

Mistake 1: Using the Wrong GA4 Property

What it looks like: You have two or three GA4 properties in your account. One has data, one has nothing, one has some. You're not sure which is "real."

Why it happens: Multiple people set up GA4 at different times, or you followed different tutorials that created different properties.

How to fix it: Check your Shopify Google integration settings and your theme code. Find which Measurement ID (G-XXXXXXXXXX) is actually on your site. Then make sure that ID's property is the one you're looking at in GA4.

Cost: You've been analysing the wrong data. Every decision made from that data may be wrong.

Mistake 2: Not Filtering Internal Traffic

What it looks like: Your conversion rate is suspiciously low (you're counting your own "testing" sessions as unconverted traffic). Or your traffic numbers seem high relative to your revenue.

Why it happens: Nobody set up an IP exclusion filter, or the filter was set up but never activated (still in "Testing" mode).

How to fix it: Follow the internal traffic filter steps in Part 1. Check that the filter is set to “Active” not “Testing.”

Cost: Misleading conversion rates and session data. Decisions made to “improve” a conversion rate that was actually fine.

Mistake 3: Payment Gateway Referral Pollution

What it looks like: A huge percentage of your revenue is attributed to “paypal / referral” or “afterpay.com / referral.” Or all your revenue shows as “direct” despite running ads.

Why it happens: Payment gateways redirect customers away from your store and back. Without referral exclusions, GA4 treats the return trip as a new session from that payment provider.

How to fix it: Add all your payment gateways to the unwanted referrals list (covered in Part 1, Step 6).

Cost: You can’t see where your revenue is actually coming from. Channel attribution is completely unreliable.

Mistake 4: No UTM Parameters on Email Links

What it looks like: Email shows as a tiny slice of your traffic in GA4, despite sending thousands of emails per month. Most revenue is attributed to “direct.”

Why it happens: Email links without UTM parameters look like direct traffic to GA4. People click from their email client, and GA4 has no referrer to identify the source.

How to fix it: Add UTM parameters to all links in all marketing emails. Set up a naming convention and enforce it.

Cost: You can’t measure your email marketing ROI in GA4. Investment decisions about email strategy are made blind.

Mistake 5: Duplicate Tracking Firing Twice

What it looks like: GA4 shows revenue approximately double what Shopify shows. Or pageview counts seem implausibly high.

Why it happens: You added GA4 via the Shopify Google integration and via a manually added script in your theme and via a GTM container. Three ways in = triple counting.

How to fix it: 1. Check your theme.liquid for any `gtag.js` or `analytics.js` scripts 2. Check GTM for a GA4 Configuration tag 3. Check which Shopify apps are injecting GA4 tags

You want exactly ONE of these firing. Remove all others.

Cost: Every metric is inflated. Revenue looks great, conversion rate looks terrible. Both impressions are wrong.

Mistake 6: Checkout Tracking Is Broken

What it looks like: You see view_item and add_to_cart events in GA4, but purchase events are missing or extremely low compared to Shopify orders.

Why it happens: The tracking doesn't follow users through the checkout. Common causes: Shopify Plus checkout.liquid not including the tracking code, GTM not firing on order confirmation, cross-domain tracking not set up.

How to fix it: Place a test order and watch GA4 Realtime. If the purchase event doesn't fire, trace back through the checkout flow to find where tracking drops.

Cost: Your most important conversion data is missing. You're optimising campaigns without knowing which ones actually drive purchases.

Mistake 7: Auto-Tagging Disabled in Google Ads

What it looks like: Google Ads traffic shows up in GA4 as “google / cpc” but there’s no campaign or keyword breakdown. Or GA4 and Google Ads show wildly different click numbers.

Why it happens: Auto-tagging (the `gclid` parameter) is disabled in Google Ads, or it’s being stripped by the website before GA4 can read it.

How to fix it: 1. In Google Ads → **Settings → Account Settings** 2. Under **Tracking**, ensure **Auto-tagging** is set to “Yes” 3. If your site strips URL parameters, you’ll need server-side tagging or a manual fix

Cost: No campaign-level ROAS data. You’re running Google Ads without knowing which campaigns are actually driving sales.

Mistake 8: Confusing Sessions With Users

What it looks like: You proudly report “100,000 sessions this month.” Your revenue is $8,000. That’s a 0.008% conversion rate. Something seems very wrong.

Why it happens: Sessions and users are different. One user can create multiple sessions — and some tools (especially with retargeting campaigns) count every ad impression visit as a session, inflating the denominator.

Sessions = total number of visits (one user can create many sessions) Users = unique people (more representative of actual reach)

How to fix it: When reporting traffic, use **Users** not Sessions. When calculating conversion rate, use the **User conversion rate** metric in GA4 (not session conversion rate, which is lower because one user can have many sessions).

Cost: Your conversion rate looks artificially terrible, leading to unnecessary “fixes” for a problem that doesn’t exist.

Mistake 9: Not Setting Data Retention to 14 Months

What it looks like: You try to compare this April to last April in a custom exploration. The data only goes back 2 months. You have no historical comparison.

Why it happens: GA4 defaults to 2-month retention for event data. Nobody changed it.

How to fix it: Admin → Data Settings → Data Retention → Change to 14 months → Save. (Covered in Part 1, Step 3.)

Cost: You lose year-on-year comparison ability. You can't track whether you're actually growing or just having a seasonal bump.

Mistake 10: Ignoring the GA4 / Shopify Revenue Discrepancy

What it looks like: GA4 shows $15,000 revenue for the month. Shopify shows $22,000. You shrug and trust one or the other.

Why it happens: GA4 can miss transactions due to ad blockers, users closing the browser before the confirmation page loads, slow internet connections, or broken tracking on the checkout flow.

This is normal to a point. A 10-15% discrepancy between GA4 and Shopify is expected. More than 20% consistently means something is broken.

How to fix it: Investigate the checkout tracking flow (see Mistake 6 above). If the gap persists, consider Littledata (server-side tracking) to close the gap.

Cost: You're making channel attribution decisions based on a GA4 dataset that's missing 30%+ of transactions. Your highest-converting channel might be the most under-counted one.

Mistake 11: Using Bounce Rate Without Context

What it looks like: “Our bounce rate is 70%, that’s terrible!” or “Our bounce rate is 30%, that’s great!” — stated without knowing what’s normal for that page or channel.

Why it matters: In GA4, a “bounce” (called “non-engaged session”) is a session where a user doesn’t scroll 90% of the page, watch a video, click anything, or spend more than 10 seconds. Context matters enormously.

A blog post with 80% bounce rate is fine — people read it and left satisfied. A product page with 80% bounce rate is worth investigating. A landing page from paid ads with 85% bounce rate is a problem.

How to fix it: Segment bounce rate by page type and channel. Compare similar pages to each other. Look for pages performing worse than their peers, not worse than an arbitrary standard.

Mistake 12: Never Checking Search Console

What it looks like: The store has been “doing SEO” for two years. Organic traffic is flat. Nobody has looked at Search Console in months.

Why it happens: Search Console feels optional when you’re busy. It’s not dramatic. It doesn’t change daily.

Why it matters: Search Console is where you find out about: - Google manual actions (penalties) that tank your rankings - Indexing issues that prevent pages from appearing in search - Crawl errors that damage Google’s view of your site - Queries where you’re ranking on page 2 and could be on page 1 with small improvements

How to fix it: Add Search Console to your monthly deep dive. Check the Coverage report and Core Web Vitals every month. Review the Performance report quarterly.

Cost: Missed SEO opportunities, undetected penalties, slow indexing of new products.

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10. Bonus: Analytics Audit Checklist

Use this checklist to audit your analytics setup in one focused session. Print it out, work through it, tick each item off. Anything unchecked is a gap to fix.

Section A: GA4 Property Setup

- [ ] GA4 property exists with correct name
- [ ] Property uses your local timezone (e.g., Australia/Sydney)
- [ ] Currency set to AUD (or your local currency)
- [ ] Data retention set to 14 months
- [ ] Internal traffic filter created AND set to Active
- [ ] Web data stream exists and is connected to your website
- [ ] Enhanced Measurement is turned on in your data stream
- [ ] Cross-domain tracking configured (if applicable)
- [ ] Payment gateways added to unwanted referrals list
- [ ] Google Signals enabled
- [ ] Search Console linked to GA4 property
- [ ] Google Ads linked to GA4 property (if running ads)
- [ ]

`purchase` event marked as a conversion

- [ ] `begin_checkout` event marked as a conversion

Section B: Shopify Integration

- [ ] Only ONE GA4 integration method is active (not multiple)
- [ ] GA4 fires on your homepage (verified via Realtime)
- [ ] GA4 fires on product pages (verified via Realtime)
- [ ] `view_item` event fires on product pages (verified via Realtime)
- [ ] `add_to_cart` event fires when adding to cart (verified via Realtime)
- [ ] `begin_checkout` event fires when checkout is started (verified via Realtime)
- [ ] `purchase` event fires on order confirmation (verified via test order)
- [ ] Revenue data appears in GA4 purchase events (matches Shopify)
- [ ] GA4 revenue is within 15% of Shopify revenue (monthly comparison)

Section C: Google Ads (If Applicable)

- [ ] Google Ads account linked to GA4
- [ ] Auto-tagging is enabled in Google Ads
- [ ]

- [ ] GA4 purchase conversion imported into Google Ads OR direct conversion tag installed
- [ ] Conversion value set to “use transaction value” (not fixed value)
- [ ] Remarketing audiences shared from GA4 to Google Ads
- [ ] At least one active Shopping campaign OR Search campaign
- [ ] Negative keyword list exists and is actively managed
- [ ] At least one campaign using Target ROAS or Target CPA bidding

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Section D: Google Search Console

- [ ] Domain property verified in Search Console
- [ ] Sitemap submitted (`/sitemap.xml`)
- [ ] Search Console linked to GA4
- [ ] No manual actions listed (check under Security & Manual Actions)
- [ ] Index coverage rate above 80%
- [ ] Core Web Vitals checked within last 30 days
- [ ] Top 10 organic queries reviewed within last 30 days

Section E: Reporting & Monitoring

- [ ]

- [ ] Revenue by Channel exploration saved in GA4
- [ ] Purchase Funnel exploration saved in GA4
- [ ] Landing Page Revenue exploration saved in GA4
- [ ] Looker Studio dashboard created (or Scheduled Reports set up)
- [ ] Weekly analytics ritual scheduled (same time each week)
- [ ] Monthly deep dive scheduled (first Monday of month)
- [ ] UTM naming convention documented and shared with team
- [ ] All email marketing links include UTM parameters

Section F: Data Quality Checks

Run these checks and record the results:

CHECK	GA4 RESULT	SHOPIFY RESULT	STATUS
Last 30 days revenue	$	$	✅ / ⚠️
Last 30 days transactions	#	#	✅ / ⚠️
Last 30 days conversion rate	%	%	✅ / ⚠️

Status guide: - ✅ = within 15% agreement - ⚠️ = more than 15% discrepancy — investigate

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Section G: Red Flag Check

Answer these honestly:

- [ ] Direct traffic is less than 25% of total sessions
- [ ] No single channel accounts for more than 70% of revenue (diversification)
- [ ] Google Ads ROAS is above your break-even threshold
- [ ] Organic traffic is not declining month-over-month (3-month trend)
- [ ] Return customer rate is at or above industry benchmark for your category
- [ ] Cart abandonment rate is below 75% (ideally below 70%)
- [ ] No unexplained revenue gaps in GA4 vs Shopify (>20% discrepancy)
- [ ] Checkout flow has been personally tested in the last 30 days

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Quick Fix Priority List

If you found multiple issues, fix them in this order:

Priority 1 — Fix first (impacts all data): 1. Remove duplicate tracking 2. Fix purchase event tracking 3. Add payment gateway referral exclusions 4. Activate internal traffic filter

Priority 2 — Fix soon (impacts channel attribution): 5. Add UTM parameters to email links 6. Enable auto-tagging in Google Ads 7. Set up cross-domain tracking (if applicable)

Priority 3 — Improve over time (improves insight quality): 8. Set up Looker Studio dashboard 9. Build five core explorations 10. Establish weekly review ritual

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11. Next Steps + Ignition Agency

You’ve done the hard part. You’ve read the playbook, you know what needs to be fixed, and you have a clear picture of what “good” looks like.

Now there are two paths forward.

Path 1: Do It Yourself

Everything in this playbook can be implemented without outside help. It takes time — expect 3-5 hours for a full implementation from scratch, less if you’re just filling gaps in an existing setup.

Your to-do list:

1. Complete the GA4 setup checklist (Part 1)
2. Verify Shopify integration (Part 1, Shopify connection section)
3. Build the five core reports (Part 2)
4. Set up your weekly ritual (Part 3)
5. Connect Search Console and Google Ads (Part 4)
6. Run the full audit checklist (Section 10)
7. Fix any issues in priority order (Quick Fix Priority List)

Work through it in stages. Get the foundation solid first. Everything else builds on it.

Path 2: Get Expert Help

Some of this is genuinely technical, and technical things can go wrong in ways that are hard to diagnose without experience. If you’ve tried to set this up and

something isn't working — or if you'd rather spend your time running your business than debugging tracking — we can help.

About Ignition Agency

Ignition Agency is an Australian digital marketing and analytics consultancy. We work with Shopify store owners and ecommerce businesses who want to stop guessing and start making decisions based on accurate data.

We've set up analytics for stores doing $50k/month and stores doing $5M/month. The problems are usually the same — and the fixes are always worth it.

What we do:

- **Analytics Audits** — We go through your GA4 setup, find every gap, and give you a prioritised fix list
- **Full Analytics Implementation** — We set up GA4, GTM, Google Ads conversion tracking, and Looker Studio dashboards from scratch
- **Google Ads Management** — Campaign setup, optimisation, and reporting for Shopify stores
- **SEO** — Technical SEO, content strategy, and Search Console management
- **Ongoing Analytics Retainers** — Monthly reporting, anomaly detection, and quarterly strategy sessions

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Free 30-Minute Analytics Audit

We offer a free 30-minute analytics audit call for Shopify store owners.

In 30 minutes, we'll:

1. Review your current GA4 setup live on the call
2. Identify your top 3 tracking issues
3. Tell you which metrics to prioritise for your specific store
4. Give you honest advice on whether you need help or can handle it yourself

No sales pitch. No obligation. Just useful feedback.

Book your free audit at: ignitionagency.au/audit

Or email us directly: **hello@ignitionagency.au**

Stay Connected

Website: ignitionagency.au

Email: hello@ignitionagency.au

We publish practical ecommerce analytics guides, GA4 tutorials, and Google Ads breakdowns regularly. If you found this playbook useful, you'll find the free content valuable too.

A Final Note

Analytics isn't the goal. Better decisions are the goal. Better decisions lead to better products, better marketing, and better customer experiences — which lead to better revenue.

The numbers are just a map. You still have to do the driving.

Good luck. And if you get stuck, you know where to find us.

— The Ignition Agency Team

ignitionagency.au

Appendix A: Useful Resources

RESOURCE	URL	WHAT IT'S FOR
GA4	analytics.google.com	Your main analytics platform
Google Search Console	search.google.com/search-console	Search performance and indexing
Google Tag Manager	tagmanager.google.com	Tag management
Google Ads	ads.google.com	Paid campaign management
Looker Studio	lookerstudio.google.com	Free custom dashboards
Google Campaign URL Builder	ga-dev-tools.google/campaign-url-builder	Build UTM-tagged URLs
PageSpeed Insights	pagespeed.web.dev	Check page load performance
Google Ads Preview Tool	ads.google.com/anon/AdPreview	Preview ads without accruing impressions
GA4 Event Reference	developers.google.com/analytics/devguides/collection/ga4/reference/events	Complete GA4 event documentation
GTM Community Template Gallery	tagmanager.google.com/gallery	Pre-built tag templates

Appendix B: Glossary

Attribution — The process of crediting a marketing channel or touchpoint for a conversion.

Bounce Rate / Non-engaged Session Rate — In GA4, the percentage of sessions where a user doesn't meaningfully engage (scroll, click, watch a video, or spend 10+ seconds). Replaces the old "bounce rate" from Universal Analytics.

CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost) — Total spend to acquire a customer, from a specific channel.

CLV / LTV (Customer Lifetime Value) — The total revenue expected from a customer over their entire relationship with your business.

Cohort — A group of users who share a common characteristic within a defined time period (e.g., “everyone who made their first purchase in January 2025”).

Conversion — A desired action on your website — typically a purchase, but can be any event you mark as important.

CPC (Cost Per Click) — How much you pay each time someone clicks your ad.

CPM (Cost Per Thousand Impressions) — Ad pricing model where you pay per 1,000 times your ad is shown.

CTR (Click-Through Rate) — Percentage of people who clicked your link/ad out of those who saw it.

Data Layer — A JavaScript object used by GTM to pass information from your website to tags.

Dimension — A characteristic of your data (e.g., channel, device, country). Used to slice and filter metrics.

Enhanced Measurement — GA4 feature that automatically tracks scrolls, outbound clicks, video plays, and file downloads without additional configuration.

Event — Any interaction tracked in GA4 (pageview, click, purchase, etc.).

First-Party Data — Data you collect directly from your customers (email addresses, purchase history). Increasingly valuable as third-party cookies are phased out.

GA4 (Google Analytics 4) — Google’s current analytics platform, replacing Universal Analytics.

GCLID — Google Click Identifier, a URL parameter added by Google Ads auto-tagging to track ad clicks.

GTM (Google Tag Manager) — A tag management system that lets you deploy and manage tracking codes without editing website code.

Impression — One instance of an ad or search result being shown to a user.

Looker Studio — Google’s free data visualisation and dashboarding tool (formerly Google Data Studio).

LTV:CAC Ratio — Customer Lifetime Value divided by Customer Acquisition Cost. A ratio of 3:1 or higher indicates a sustainable business model.

Measurement ID — GA4's unique property identifier, format: G-XXXXXXXXXX.

Metric — A quantitative measurement (e.g., sessions, revenue, conversion rate).

Parameter — Additional information attached to a GA4 event (e.g., `purchase` event includes parameters like `value`, `currency`, `transaction_id`).

ROAS (Return on Ad Spend) — Revenue generated divided by advertising spend.

RFM Analysis — Customer segmentation model based on Recency, Frequency, and Monetary value.

Search Console — Google's free tool for monitoring and troubleshooting a site's presence in Google Search.

Session — A period of activity from a single user on your website. By default in GA4, a session ends after 30 minutes of inactivity.

UTM Parameters — Tracking codes added to URLs to identify the source of traffic in analytics.

Universal Analytics (UA) — Google's previous analytics platform (deprecated July 2023).

Appendix C: GA4 Event Parameter Reference

When sending ecommerce events, include these parameters for rich reporting:

`purchase` **event parameters:**

```
{
  transaction_id: "T_12345",        // Required — unique order ID
  value: 99.90,                      // Required — total order value
  currency: "AUD",                   // Required
  coupon: "SUMMER10",                // Optional — discount code used
  shipping: 9.95,                    // Optional
  tax: 9.08,                         // Optional
  items: [
    {
```

```
      item_id: "SKU_12345",           // Product SKU or ID
      item_name: "Blue Linen Shirt",  // Product name
      item_brand: "Your Brand",       // Brand name
      item_category: "Apparel",       // Product category
      item_variant: "Medium / Blue",  // Selected variant
      price: 89.95,                   // Unit price
      quantity: 1                     // Quantity purchased
    }
  ]
}
```

`add_to_cart` **event parameters:**

```
{
  currency: "AUD",
  value: 89.95,           // Value of items added
  items: [
    {
      item_id: "SKU_12345",
      item_name: "Blue Linen Shirt",
      item_variant: "Medium / Blue",
      price: 89.95,
      quantity: 1
    }
  ]
}
```

End of Playbook

Stop Flying Blind: The Complete GA4 + Shopify Analytics Setup for Small Business

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